



Core of the sport: Classification is the foundation that determines fairness and eligibility in every para sport. It is not a simple tick-box exercise but an extensive process overseen by trained international experts. GETTY IMAGES

Building systems

While the Grand Prix has had a massive impact for athletes, its long-term value lies in creating a system that can sustain itself. With classifications now more accessible, athletes from smaller towns and rural regions can begin entering the system, steadily broadening the national talent base.

"Parathletes in all of Europe, including the UK, are fewer than the disabled population of just one Indian state. So, the potential is massive," he said.

However, that kind of scale can only be tapped if opportunities reach beyond metros.

Domestic classification and trained officials can help open doors at the grassroot level. "It doesn't make sense to have classifiers and officials concentrated only in big cities. We need to spread them

across the country to give every promising athlete a chance," Rana emphasised.

If the system continues to align — with more slots, stronger technical expertise, and wider grassroots access — India's para sport ecosystem can enter a phase of self-reliance and sustained growth. For athletes, it will mean fewer barriers, clearer pathways, and the confidence to train knowing that the system will support them.

The upcoming World Para Athletics Championships in New Delhi, where India expects its largest-ever contingent (73 athletes) to compete, could prove to be a watershed moment.

But beyond the numbers, it signals permanence — that para sport in India is no longer dependent on others to take its first steps but beginning to chart its own future.



Fact file

A classified athlete is given a number along with a prefix: a 'T', which stands for 'track', or an 'F' for 'field'. The number also represents the level of impairment; the lower the number within each impairment type, the more severe the impairment. There are ten eligible impairment types, further divided into classes specific to each sport.

Running and jumping (16 classes)

T11-13 — Visual impairment

T20 — Intellectual impairment

T35-38 — Co-ordination impairments

T40-41 — Short stature

T42-44 — Lower limb affected by limb deficiency, leg length difference, impaired muscle power or impaired range of movement

T45-47 — Upper limbs affected by limb deficiency, impaired muscle power or impaired range of movement

Wheelchair racing (seven classes)

T32-34 — Co-ordination impairments

T51-54 — Limb deficiency, leg length difference, impaired muscle power or impaired range of movement

Standing throws (15 classes)

F11-13 — Visual impairment

F20 — Intellectual impairment

F35-38 — Co-ordination impairments

F40-41 — Short stature

F42-44 — Lower limb affected by limb deficiency, leg length difference, impaired muscle power or impaired range of movement

F45-46 — Upper limb/s affected by limb deficiency, impaired muscle power or impaired range of movement

Seated throws (11 classes)

F31-34 — Coordination impairments

F51-57 — Limb deficiency, leg length difference, impaired muscle power or impaired range of movement

Source: www.paralympic.org